

12. Ornaments

I participated in a Christmas ornament exchange with a childhood friend for many years. This very informal arrangement allowed us to select a suitable, affordable gift; when I am decorating my tree, I get to remember the ornaments she bought or made for me. You'll find ornaments anywhere, but I like shopping at family-owned gift shops for memorable, one-of-a-kind ones.

13. Chocolate chess pie

This gift involves cooking but is simple, absolutely delicious, and freezes exceptionally well. I've been buying them at my church bazaar for a few years and finally snagged the recipe, which makes two pies for a cost per pie of about \$6.

Here's the recipe:

Ingredients: 4 squares unsweetened baking chocolate; 2 sticks butter; 4 eggs, lightly beaten; 2½ cups sugar; ½ cup warm milk; 1 teaspoon vanilla; 2 x 9-inch pie crusts.

Instructions: Melt chocolate and butter over low heat. Temper the eggs with the chocolate and add to chocolate/butter mixture (add a small amount of chocolate to the eggs). Add

sugar, milk, and vanilla. Mix well. Bake at 300° for 40 minutes; turn oven off and leave pies in for 5 more minutes. Remove to racks to cool.

14. Potato soup jar



This potato soup is a dried version that lets the recipient create a home-made lunch at a moment's notice by adding boiling water.

Mix all the ingredients (1¾ cups instant mashed potatoes, 1½ cups dry milk, 2 tablespoons instant chicken bouillon, 2 teaspoons dried minced onion, and 1½ teaspoons of Italian seasoning), place in a quart jar (you can buy a canning jar or plastic quart container, or clean out a spaghetti sauce jar); add a bow on the top and a tag that gives instructions: "Bone-warming Potato Soup: Place ½ cup mix in soup bowl and add 1 cup boiling water. Stir until smooth."

You can make this soup for approximately \$3.50 per gift.

15. Movie-night basket

Assemble a movie-night basket (or gift bag) with a DVD found in the bargain bin at any entertainment store; add a couple of packs of microwave popcorn and your favorite drink mix.